flock user guide

flock gives you **one control panel for every BirdDog Play decoder you own**. It finds them on the network, shows them in one place, and lets you change settings across a whole group at once.

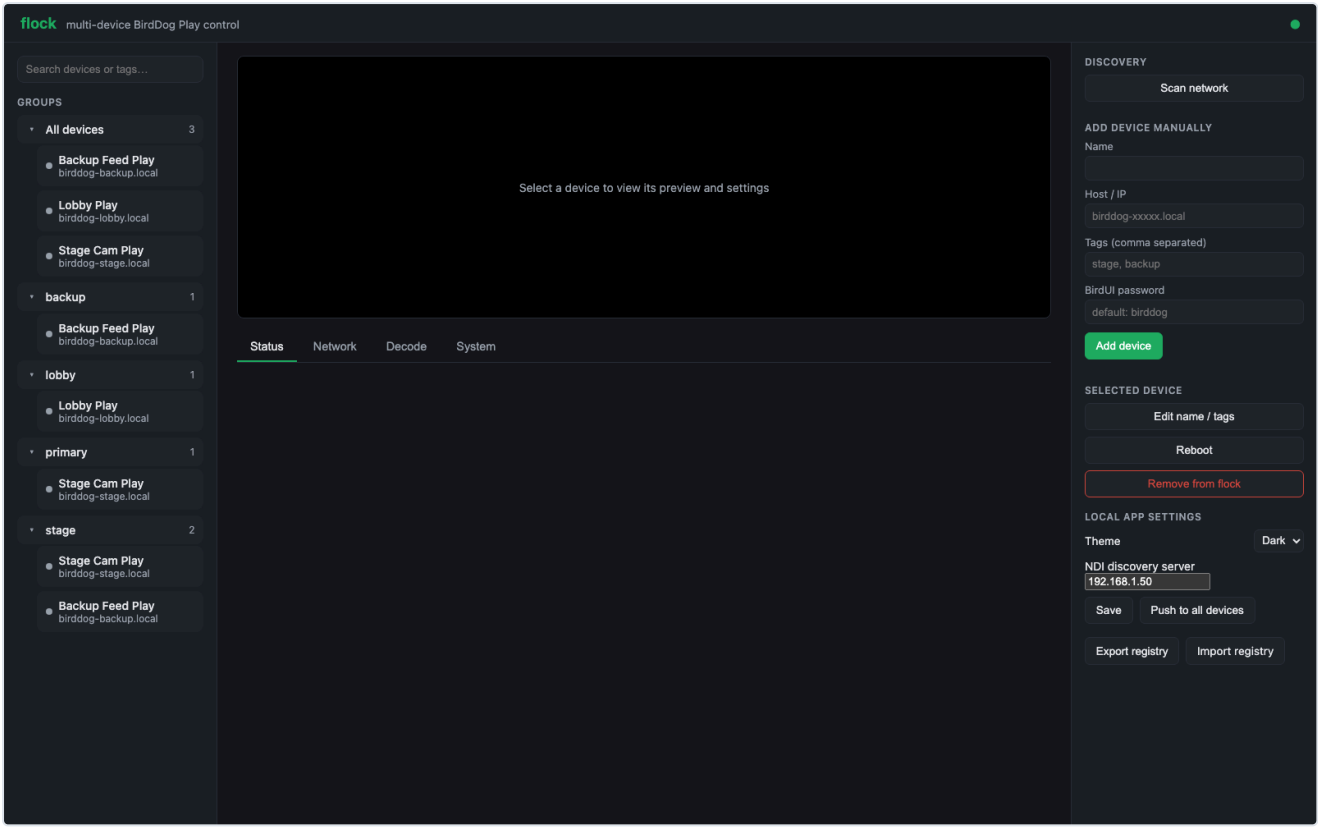
Out of the box each Play has its own BirdUI web page, which is fine for one unit and painful for twenty.

> **Before you rely on this:** flock has been used against **both a simulated device and a real one**, including live reads and a **real settings write** (routing an actual NDI source to a physical unit's HDMI output). That's more evidence than most tools of this kind can show. It's still an early-stage project, though, and a successful write on one path doesn't prove every path; the README's Status section sets out which operations are covered.

Getting started

1. Run flock, either as its own desktop tray app or with `cargo run -p flock`.
2. Open the web UI.
3. **Scan network**: flock probes the local subnet for Play devices.
4. Add the ones you want to manage. Each needs its BirdUI password.

Passwords are **encrypted before being written to disk**, and the API never returns them once they're stored. If you need to change one, re-enter it; you can't read back what's there.



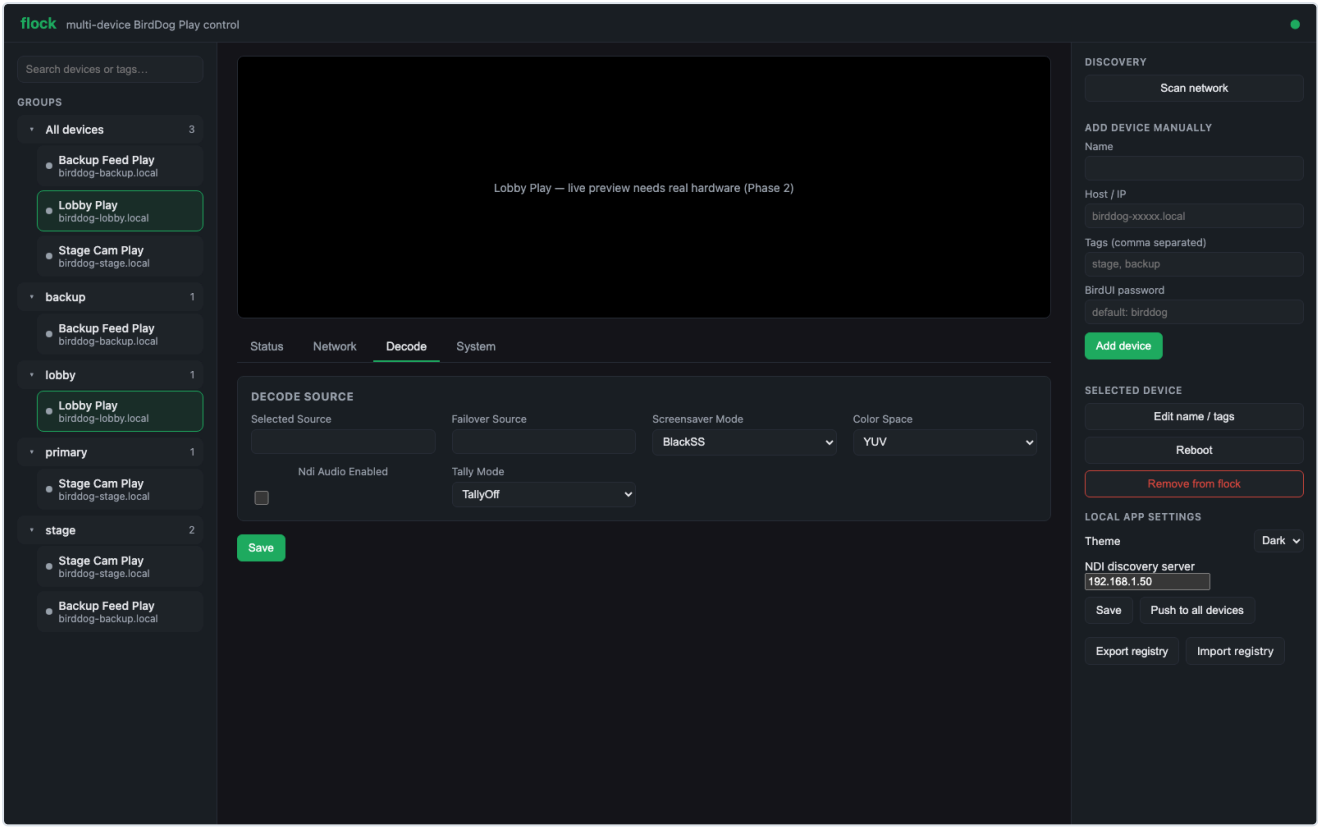
You can also add devices by hand (name, host, tags and password), which is the way to go when a unit is on another subnet and discovery can't reach it.

Per-device settings

Select a device and you get its tabs:

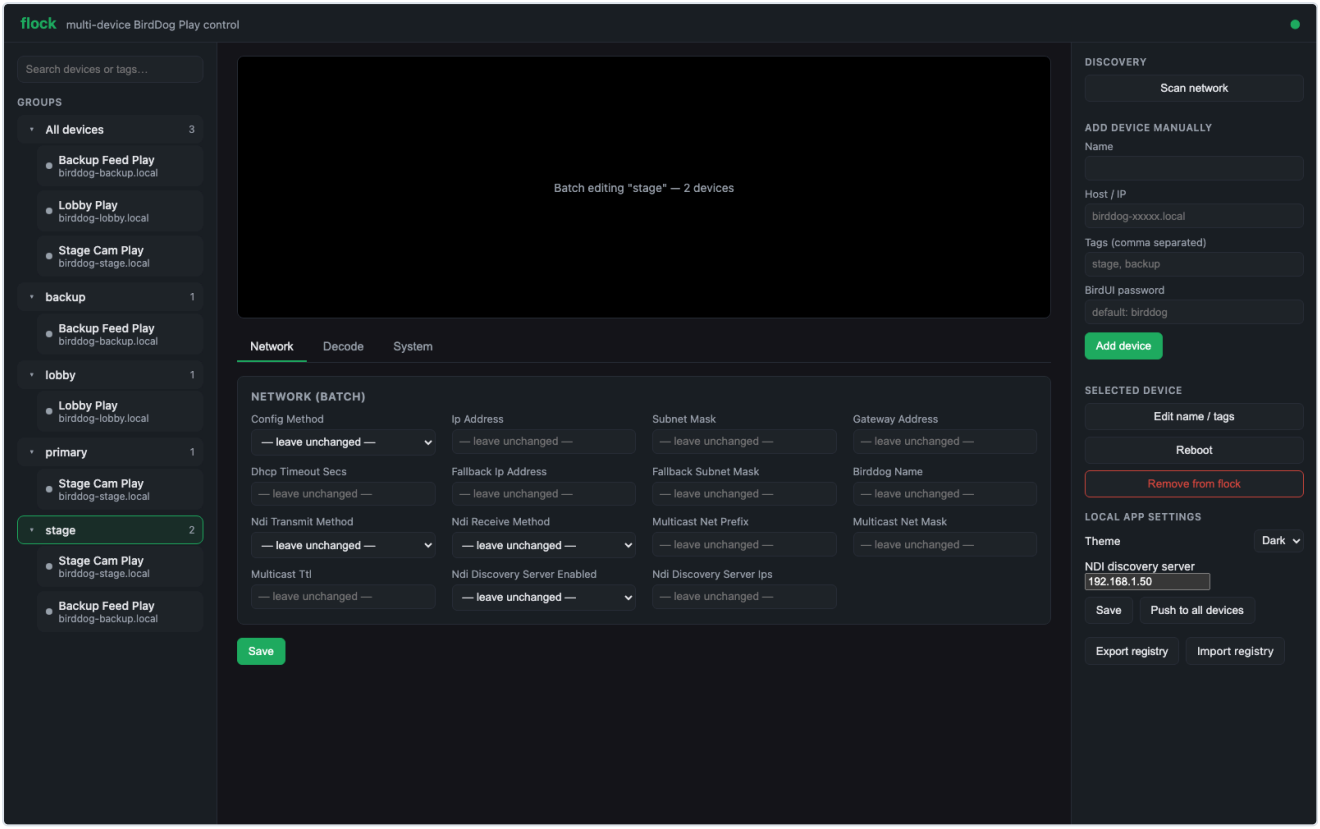
Tab	What it covers
Status	Is it up, and what is it doing
Decode	Which NDI or SRT source it is playing. **The one you will use most.**
Network	Addressing, NDI transmit/receive method, multicast, discovery server
System	Device-level settings

Plus **Reboot**, **Edit name / tags**, and a preview. It's live video when the device is decoding an SRT source in caller or rendezvous mode: flock pulls the same source itself, since the Play doesn't expose its HDMI output over the network, and that needs an `ffmpeg` with SRT input on the machine running flock. For an NDI source or an SRT listener, the box says why there's no picture.



Groups — the point of flock

Tag your devices however suits the job: by room, hall or purpose. Tags become groups in the sidebar, and a device can be in several. Select a **group** rather than a device and the settings tabs become batch editors.



Every field defaults to `— leave unchanged —`. That's what makes group editing safe to use: you set the two fields you mean to change, and the other fourteen aren't touched on any device in the group.

> **Save writes to every device in the group at once.** Check what's in a tag before you fire a group operation. A mistake here is multiplied by the size of the group, and these are decoders driving screens people may be watching.

Export registry and **Import registry** move your whole device list and tagging between machines, which is how a rig's show file gets from the office to site.

Locking it down

By default flock has **no login**, on the assumption it's on a trusted production LAN.

To require a password, set `admin_password` under `[web]` in the config. Then every page and API call needs a session. Two things to know:

- **Sessions live in memory only.** Restarting flock logs everyone out. That's intentional for a single-operator tool.
- **After 5 failed logins there's a 30-second lockout**, applied **process-wide** rather than per client. There's only one password, so one client guessing wrong briefly holds up everyone's next attempt.

Even with a password set, flock is designed for a **trusted operations network**. Don't put it on the public internet.

Troubleshooting

Symptom	Cause
Scan finds nothing	flock and the devices must be on the same subnet. Discovery is a subnet probe, so it will not cross a router. Check for a firewall, and for client isolation on wireless.
A device shows unreachable after working	Its IP probably changed. Check the Network tab, or re-scan.
A settings write is rejected	Usually a wrong or changed BirdUI password. Re-enter it on the device.
I can't see the password I entered	By design — redacted in every response and encrypted on disk.
A group save changed fields I didn't touch	Shouldn't happen: unset fields are `— leave unchanged —`. Worth reporting.
Everyone got logged out	flock restarted. Sessions are in-memory.
Login says I'm locked out	Five failed attempts triggers a 30-second cooldown, process-wide. Wait it out.

A note on care

flock writes settings to **real decoders on a live network**. A bad decode change can black out a screen in front of an audience.

Read before you write, check group membership before group operations, and if you're developing against flock rather than operating it, use the mock device backend instead of real hardware.

See also

- API.md: the HTTP surface
- architecture.md: the device trait and the adapters behind it
- DEVELOPING.md · diagnostics.md · roadmap.md

- README: status, coverage and downloads
